

Topic 5.3 - Professionalism in the digital age

A real classroom situation

A donor gives Ms Sundas's school forty tablets.

There is no budget for electricity beyond the existing supply, which fails most afternoons in summer. No one has been trained. The tablets carry a drill application in English, which is the third language of most of her Class 5. The district office has asked for photographs of the tablets in use for a report.

Ms Sundas has thirty minutes a day in which the tablets might realistically be used, and a class that cannot yet read fluently in any language. What should she do?

Explanation

Pressure to integrate technology

The pressure is real and it comes from several directions at once: donors with equipment, district offices with targets, private schools advertising their facilities, and a general public belief that technology and modernity are the same thing.

Very little of that pressure originates in a question about learning. This is the first thing to notice, and it is not cynicism: a donor measuring tablets delivered, an officer measuring photographs filed, and a parent comparing schools are all doing something reasonable from where they stand. None of them is measuring whether a child reads better.

Hennessy and colleagues (2022) reviewed the use of technology for **teacher professional development** in low- and middle-income countries. Note that scope carefully: their subject is technology for developing teachers, not technology in the hands of pupils, so their review cannot settle Ms Sundas's tablet question. What it does establish is that teacher development opportunities in such countries are limited and often not informed by research evidence, that technology offers real potential to extend both formal programmes and informal peer learning, and that outcomes so far are mixed. Mixed is the operative word, and it is the honest summary for educational technology generally: it does some things well, many things poorly, and nothing automatically.

So the professional skill is not enthusiasm and not refusal. It is judgement about particular uses, and the figure above gives the three questions worth asking of any of them.

What does it add that was not possible before? A projector that shows a diagram too complex to draw by hand adds something. A tablet drilling multiplication that a worksheet drills equally well adds convenience at best.

What does it cost? Not only money. Time to set up, time lost when it fails, training you do not have, and attention spent on the device rather than the content.

What does it replace that was already working? This is the question nobody asks and it is the most important. A video lesson replacing a teacher's own explanation removes the one thing a video cannot do, which is notice that a particular pupil has not understood and stop.

Applied to Ms Sundas: the tablets add English drill to a class that cannot decode, cost her the only thirty minutes she has, depend on electricity that fails, and would replace reading practice that is the actual bottleneck. The defensible answer is that she uses them minimally, if at all, for their stated purpose, and says so plainly when asked. That is a harder answer to give than to write, which is why this is a professionalism topic and not a technology topic.

The misconception to name: **integrating technology means using it in every lesson.** It does not. Integrating technology means deciding where it earns its place, which sometimes means almost nowhere, and being able to

justify that decision in the same terms you would justify any other instructional choice.

Responsible use of digital platforms and resources

Unit 2 established a teacher's obligations toward pupils, parents, colleagues and the profession. **None of them changes because the medium changed.** The power imbalance that makes a private conversation with a pupil a matter of care does not weaken because the conversation is on a phone.

Four situations account for most of the difficulty, and the figure above places them.

Private messaging with pupils. The default is not to. Where contact is necessary, use a group rather than a private thread, or a channel a parent or colleague can see. This protects the pupil and it protects you, and the second reason is not the important one.

Class groups on messaging platforms. Useful, and they carry three quiet problems: pupils without a phone are excluded from whatever is announced there; the group runs at all hours, so the expectation of a teacher's availability expands without anyone deciding it should; and a message sent in haste is permanent and forwardable. Agree the hours and the purpose when the group is created, and put anything that matters through the school's official route as well.

Your personal accounts. Discussed in Unit 2 and worth repeating because trainees resist it: the claim that a personal account is private is reasonable about privacy and false about professional consequence. A photograph of a class, a complaint about a named pupil, or material a parent would read as evidence of unfairness has professional consequences whoever owns the account.

Pupil data and images. Marks, assessment records, medical or family information, and photographs of children are not yours to circulate. A photograph of a class posted to demonstrate that tablets were used, as the district asked of Ms Sundas, involves children who did not consent and cannot refuse.

Digital resources. Two obligations. Check what you take: a worksheet found online may be wrong, may be pitched for a different curriculum, and frequently is not aligned to anything your pupils are being examined on. And credit what you use, because the citation discipline Unit 4 expects of your own evidence applies to your teaching materials too.

Activity: Judge four uses

Work in pairs. Below are four proposed classroom uses of technology. Take each through the three questions - what does it add, what does it cost, what does it replace that was working - and reach a verdict.

1. A projector used to display the same notes the teacher would otherwise write on the board.
2. A WhatsApp group for a Class 9 to receive homework reminders.
3. Forty tablets running an English drill application in a class that cannot decode fluently.
4. A short video of a science experiment the school has no equipment to perform.

Then swap verdicts with another pair and challenge one of theirs. Allow 25 minutes.

Note which of the four divides the room. In most cohorts it is the second, because the costs are social rather than technical and therefore easy to miss.

Check your understanding

1. Name three sources of pressure to integrate technology, and state what each actually measures. (*Understand*)
2. State the three questions to ask of any proposed classroom use of technology. (*Remember*)
3. Apply the three questions to the tablets in Ms Sundas's school and reach a verdict. (*Apply*)
4. Explain why "what does it replace that was already working" is the question most often missed. (*Analyze*)

5. Give two quiet problems with a class messaging group that are not about the technology itself. (*Understand*)
6. Explain why a teacher's obligations do not weaken when a conversation moves to a phone. (*Understand*)

Summary

Pressure to integrate technology comes from donors, districts, competing schools and public belief, and almost none of it originates in a question about learning. Research on technology for teacher development in low- and middle-income countries reports mixed outcomes, and mixed is the honest summary for educational technology generally: it does some things well, many poorly, and nothing automatically.

The professional skill is judgement about particular uses, tested by three questions: what does it add that was not possible before, what does it cost in money, time, training and reliability, and what does it replace that was already working. The third is the one most often missed. Integrating technology means deciding where it earns its place, not using it everywhere.

Obligations do not change with the medium. Private messaging with pupils has a default of no; class groups exclude pupils without phones, expand availability by default and are permanent; personal accounts carry professional consequence whatever their privacy settings; and pupil data and images are not a teacher's to circulate. Digital resources must be checked for accuracy and alignment, and credited.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can name where the pressure to use technology comes from and what each source measures.
- ☐ I can apply the three questions to a proposed use and reach a defensible verdict.
- ☐ I can explain why replacing something that was working is a real cost.

- ☐ I can state the default for private contact with pupils and why it exists.
- ☐ I can identify what pupil information and images I may not circulate.

Try this at your practicum school

Find one use of technology in your practicum school, however small: a projector, a phone used for a register, a class group, a photocopied resource taken from the internet.

Take it through the three questions and write half a page. Pay particular attention to the third question, and ask the teacher directly what the technology replaced. The common finding is either that it replaced nothing, which is fine, or that it replaced something the teacher misses, which is the interesting case.

Summative task

Write 400 to 450 words.

Ms Sundas has forty tablets, unreliable electricity, an untrained staff, a drill application in a third language, a class that cannot decode, and a district asking for photographs.

Decide what she should do and defend it. Work at least two of the proposed uses through the three questions, state what you would tell the district office and in what terms, and address the objection that refusing to use a donated resource is ungrateful and will harm the school's standing with donors.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Use of the three questions (Apply)	Applies all three to specific uses, including what is replaced
Handling the photograph request	Recognises the pupil-image issue rather than treating the request as merely administrative

Criterion	What a strong response does
Answering the objection (Evaluate)	Takes the donor-relations cost seriously and proposes something defensible that does not require pretending the tablets are working
Realism	The recommendation is something a teacher in her position could actually carry out

Further reading

- Hennessy, S., D'Angelo, S., McIntyre, N., Koomar, S., Kreimeia, A., Cao, L., Brugha, M., & Zubairi, A. (2022). Technology use for teacher professional development in low- and middle-income countries: A systematic review. *Computers and Education Open*, 3, 100080.
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.caeo.2022.100080> The subject is teacher development, not pupils' classroom use.

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